

**Fwd: Do Not Pass the proposed deadlines for Poll Watchers to register**

1 message

Fri, Feb 13, 2026 at 12:09 PM



----- Forwarded message -----

From: **Mary Nelson**

Date: Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 4:15 PM

Subject: Do Not Pass the proposed deadlines for Poll Watchers to register

To: <info.sbe@maryland.gov>

Cc:

Changing a deadline for registering unduly handicaps the poll watchers and challengers from both parties. It is hard enough to get people committed day by day. To insist that everything be lined up prior to Day 1 of Early Voting poses an undue hardship on candidates, parties and Central Committees and really serves no purpose.

As a Chief Judge, I have no problem working with the current regulations and would prefer not to add one more problem when people appear with the paperwork and get turned away. You don't want to disenfranchise voters and these poll watchers and challengers are part of the election process and are working within the system in an orderly fashion.

Please leave the regs as they stand.

Thank You,
Mary Nelson
Chief Judge, Cecil County

Message ID	<CAOLH-LEeDRmBN-VovMi4bS-YG4R7-y6RNhYcfs8BHd87JkSUeg@mail.gmail.com>
From	"Mary Nelson" [REDACTED]
To	<info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 04:14 PM(Incoming)
Subject	Do Not Pass the proposed deadlines for Poll Watchers to register
Thread Subject	Do Not Pass the proposed deadlines for Poll Watchers to register
Return-Path	[REDACTED]
Changing a deadline for registering unduly handicaps the poll watchers and challengers from both parties. It is hard enough to get people committed day by day. To insist that everything be lined up prior to Day 1 of Early Voting poses an undue hardship on candidates, parties and Central Committees and really serves no purpose. As a Chief Judge, I have no problem working with the current regulations and would prefer not to add one more problem when people appear with the paperwork and get turned away. You don't want to disenfranchise voters and these poll watchers and challengers are part of the election process and are working within the system in an orderly fashion. Please leave the regs as they stand. Thank You, Mary Nelson Chief Judge, Cecil County	

Message ID	<543632960.876490.1770066309535@connect.xfinity.com>
From	"RONALD Calabrese" [REDACTED]
To	"mailto:info.sbe@maryland.gov" <info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 04:05 PM(Incoming)
Subject	Election Watcher
Thread Subject	Election Watcher
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

Subject:Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process

I strongly request that the State Board of Elections keep the Challenger and Watcher process unchanged and not impose any new deadline.

The signed form from a designated entity should remain sufficient. Adding a new deadline would be unreasonable, create confusion, and lead to unnecessary conflict at polling places when citizens—unaware of the change—are denied entry despite having valid documentation. This would place an unfair burden on Election Judges and disrupt orderly election administration.

For these reasons, the SBE should not add this deadline.

Respectfully submitted,

Ronald J. Calabrese

Baltimore County Central Committee

Message ID	<CALOXsH3FRysFUF6uHXJGegZHV8WSOTgk+eoFnykUL-KKcpbSYg@mail.gmail.com>
From	"Pamela Ciliberti" [REDACTED]
To	"info.sbe@maryland.gov" <info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 03:55 PM (Incoming)
Subject	Opposition to SBE CHANGES to Challenger and Watcher regulations
Thread Subject	Opposition to SBE CHANGES to Challenger and Watcher regulations
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

I strongly request that the State Board of Elections keep the Challenger and Watcher process unchanged and not impose any new deadline.

The signed form from a designated entity should remain sufficient. Adding a new deadline would be unreasonable, create confusion, and lead to unnecessary conflict at polling places when citizens—unaware of the change—are denied entry despite having valid documentation. This would place an unfair burden on Election Judges and disrupt orderly election administration.

For these reasons, the SBE should not add this deadline.

Respectfully submitted,

Pamela Ciliberti

Chair

Frederick County Republican Central Committee

Message ID	<ul5wmvAQSVxC6XkOJRR3zRusdDOrOM00aaxpgZYqkawnPpocZluc7aeN1Xr493R-_lt7_FF72tPeppUVa0E_zrHUty7DztYzYoVDrRi-izw=@proton.me>
From	"Ray Smith" [REDACTED]
To	"info.sbe@maryland.gov" <info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 03:49 PM (Incoming)
Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Thread Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

I strongly request that the State Board of Elections keep the Challenger and Watcher process unchanged and not impose any new deadline.

The signed form from a designated entity should remain sufficient. Adding a new deadline would be unreasonable, create confusion, and lead to unnecessary conflict at polling places when citizens—unaware of the change—are denied entry despite having valid documentation.

This would place an unfair burden on Election Judges and disrupt orderly election administration.

For these reasons, the SBE should not add this deadline.

Thank you for your attention to this matter.

Sincerely,

Raymond Smith

Baltimore County Republican Central Committee

Election Law § 10-311

(a) (1) The following persons or entities have the right to designate a registered voter as a challenger or a watcher at each place of registration and election:

- (i) the State Board for any polling place in the State;
- (ii) a local board for any polling place located in the county of the local board;
- (iii) a candidate;
- (iv) a political party; and
- (v) any other group of voters supporting or opposing a candidate, principle, or proposition on the ballot.

(2) A person who appoints a challenger or watcher may remove the challenger or watcher at any time.

(b) Except as provided in § 10-303(d)(2) of this subtitle and subsection (d) of this section, a challenger or watcher has the right to:

- (1) enter the polling place one-half hour before the polls open;
- (2) enter or be present at the polling place at any time when the polls are open;
- (3) remain in the polling place until the completion of all tasks associated with the close of the polls under § 10-314 of this subtitle and the election judges leave the polling place;
- (4) maintain a list of registered voters who have voted, or individuals who have cast provisional ballots, and take the list outside of the polling place; and
- (5) enter and leave a polling place for the purpose of taking outside of the polling place information that identifies registered voters who have cast ballots or individuals who have cast provisional ballots.

(c) (1) (i) A certificate signed by any party or candidate shall be sufficient evidence of the right of a challenger or watcher to be present in the voting room.

(ii) The State Board shall prescribe a form that shall be supplied to the challenger or watcher by the person or entity designating the challenger or watcher.

(2) A challenger or watcher shall be positioned near the election judges and inside the voting room so that the challenger or watcher may see and hear each person as the person offers to vote.

(d) (1) A challenger or watcher may not attempt to:

(i) ascertain how a voter voted or intends to vote;

(ii) converse in the polling place with any voter;

(iii) assist any voter in voting; or

(iv) physically handle an original election document.

(2) An election judge may eject a challenger or watcher who violates the prohibitions under paragraph (1) of this subsection.

(e) (1) Except as provided in paragraphs (2) and (3) of this subsection, an election judge shall permit an individual other than an accredited challenger or watcher who desires to challenge the right to vote of any other individual to enter the polling place for that purpose.

(2) A majority of the election judges may limit the number of nonaccredited challengers and watchers allowed in the polling place at any one time for the purpose of challenging the right of an individual to vote.

(3) A nonaccredited challenger or watcher shall leave the polling place as soon as a majority of the election judges decides the right to vote of the individual challenged by the challenger or watcher.

(4) In addition to restrictions provided under this subsection, all restrictions on the actions of an accredited challenger or watcher provided under this subtitle apply to a nonaccredited challenger or watcher.

Message ID	<CAAJubE4zu33Wn3nnp8=Ac2X9FpdFbHqdGU-ZF5NH5p0F+_WcTg@mail.gmail.com>
From	"Jean B" [REDACTED]
To	<info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 03:05 PM (Incoming)
Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Thread Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

Subject: Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process

All SBE,

I serve as an Election Judge/Provisional Judge each election and I strongly request that the State Board of Elections keep the Challenger and Watcher process unchanged and not impose any new deadline.

The signed form from a designated entity should remain sufficient. Adding a new deadline would be unreasonable, create confusion, and lead to unnecessary conflict at polling places when citizens—unaware of the change—are denied entry despite having valid documentation. This would place an unfair burden on Election Judges and disrupt orderly election administration.

For these reasons, the SBE should not add this deadline.

Respectfully submitted,

Jean Benhoff

Baltimore County, MD

Message ID <rn9hIL_rZY1C-2TlInC5fpbhaVGtFfGebP8qszcBlxeRNWZ_A-xkUfpiq_N1j1qjm8tvp4-AK8rslqvbtqxHhc4L9hj8kM0j6TbG5LYmwmU=@protonmail.com>

From "Kate Taylor" [REDACTED]

To "info.sbe@maryland.gov" <info.sbe@maryland.gov>

Cc [REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]
[REDACTED]

Date Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 06:23 PM (Incoming)

Subject Maintain current poll watcher process

Thread Subject Maintain current poll watcher process

Return-Path [REDACTED]

To whom it may concern;

I strongly request that the State Board of Elections keep the Challenger and Watcher process unchanged and not impose any new deadline.

The signed form from a designated entity should remain sufficient. Adding a new deadline would be unreasonable, create confusion, and lead to unnecessary conflict at polling places when citizens—unaware of the change—are denied entry despite having valid documentation. This would place an unfair burden on Election Judges and disrupt orderly election administration

For these reasons, the SBE should not add this deadline

Sincerely,
Kate Taylor

[REDACTED] cell/text

"I do my best proofreading after I hit send."

Sent from [Proton Mail](#) for iOS.

Message ID	<2F4142AE-DF65-4402-BF4F-249C0B0CABE2@gmail.com>
From	"Janice Grim [REDACTED]"
To	<info.sbe@maryland.gov> [REDACTED] [REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 07:18 PM (Incoming)
Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Thread Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Return-Path	[REDACTED]
I strongly request that the State Board of Elections keep the Challenger and Watcher process unchanged and not impose any new deadline. The signed form from a designated entity should remain sufficient. Adding a new deadline would be unreasonable, create confusion, and lead to unnecessary conflict at polling places when citizens—unaware of the change—are denied entry despite having valid documentation. This would place an unfair burden on Election Judges and disrupt orderly election administration. Observation is an important part of a free and fair democratic process. We should have MORE transparency, not less! You allow same day voter registration, but require poll watchers a limited window? For these reasons, the SBE should not add this deadline. It is truly unconscionable. Respectfully submitted, Janice Grim Baltimore County Central Committee Sent from my iPhone	

Message ID	<CADQkgMdCAfSJMQx+8dYsY=Gdg+VfH+pbd+mDgwtOQQbT=rj38A@mail.gmail.com>
From	"Neil Posner" [REDACTED]
To	<info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 07:00 PM (Incoming)
Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Process for Poll Watchers and Challengers
Thread Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Process for Poll Watchers and Challengers
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

Hello,

I am writing to request the State Board of Elections maintain the current process for Election Challengers and Watchers and refrain from passing the recently proposed COMAR amendments to these rules. The amendments being discussed would be detrimental to the election process by unduly restricting the rights of designated entities to appoint Poll Watchers/Challengers and by causing significant confusion and discord on Election Day.

Maryland Election Law states that candidates, parties, and other specified entities have "the right to designate a registered voter as a challenger or a watcher at each place of registration and election...." Further, the law states that "[a] certificate signed by any party or candidate shall be sufficient evidence of the right of a challenger or watcher to be present in the voting room." Simply, designated entities have the right to select their volunteers, and the only validation required is a certificate they sign. To impose additional requirements on this process - namely, requirements to submit pre-selected names and locations to the local Boards of Elections by a set deadline - would be a significant infringement, and seemingly a direct violation, of the Law and of the various entities' rights recognized under said law.

In addition to the lack of justification for these rule changes being considered, making the changes at this point in the middle of an election season would cause significant confusion during the election. Many candidates, party organizations, etc., are accustomed to the current rules. It is easy to foresee how many of them could be unaware of the change, attempt to designate watchers past the proposed deadline, and then find their organizations denied access at the polls, past the point by which this could be remedied, leading to significant arguments at the polls and a very messy election.

For these and other reasons, I strongly ask that the Board oppose the changes to the procedures being discussed, in the name of the rights of all involved and a smooth, fair election.

Sincerely,
Neil Posner
Baltimore County Republican Central Committee

Message ID	<CALHvPPPFJajkh29SmDKX9RQ8hU8tdpRoCTrnTJdDkn3V-r+c+A@mail.gmail.com>
From	"Barry Chodak" [REDACTED]
To	<info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 06:16 PM (Incoming)
Subject	Change for Challengers and Watchers
Thread Subject	Change for Challengers and Watchers
Return-Path	[REDACTED]
I've been a Poll Watcher and an Election Judge. The proposed change is wholly unnecessary. Elections are for citizens to participate, and this change is just another way to discourage participation. When I visited various polling places in Baltimore County, I was welcomed by the chief judges, and the process was both simple and routine. As a judge, I was inspired by the people who were willing to take time out of their day to visit and observe the process. If you add the proposed requirement, you will be adding an additional burden on the chief judges and creating an upset with those concerned citizens who jump in at the last minute to witness and be a part of our election process. I urge you to leave things as they are and withdraw the proposed change. Sincerely, Barry Chodak Baltimore County Resident and Concerned Citizen	

Message ID	<CACWKPG9mb_aA9MFEYByUU7YFY0imAP9=0J-xFjzbRsgxE8HbQ@mail.gmail.com>
From	"Shelley Aloï [REDACTED]"
To	<info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 06:04 PM (Incoming)
Subject	Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Thread Subject	Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

Members of the State Board of Elections,

I am writing to urge the State Board of Elections to maintain the existing Challenger and Watcher process. The current form from a designated entity is adequate and should remain in place. Similarly, the existing deadline works well. As such, I am requesting, do not impose a new deadline or change the required form.

A new deadline during an election year will cause undue hardship for Election Judges who already have a difficult role. To create additional confusion and possible conflict at polling places when citizens are denied entry will only complicate existing challenges.

For these reasons, the SBE should not change the process for watchers and challengers.

Sincerely,

Shelley M. Aloï

Frederick Republican County Central Committee

Message ID	<CAKgMu33CRh6YTX60LG5PHK3g-zGG+XQ7af2rG5MQxDWthvh8tA@mail.gmail.com>
From	"Kelly McGuire" [REDACTED]
To	<info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Cc	[REDACTED] [REDACTED]
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 05:54 PM (Incoming)
Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Thread Subject	Request to Maintain Existing Challenger and Watcher Process
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

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For these reasons, the SBE should not add this deadline.

Respectfully,

Kelly McGuire, Treasurer

Frederick County Republican Central Committee

Message ID	<CAKFGegfBzFMTctvncBw=+DX-L45VpnMgO0uuRweDYvkRKoTJKw@mail.gmail.com>
From	"Kate Strauch Sullivan" [REDACTED]
To	<undisclosed-recipients:>
Bcc	<info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 04:49 PM (Incoming)
Subject	No to Challengers and Watchers regulation change
Thread Subject	No to Challengers and Watchers regulation change
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

State Board Of Elections Members-

I strongly request that the State Board of Elections keep the Challenger and Watcher process unchanged and not impose any new regulations to the designation process.

Among many issue I have with the regulation change, the most egregious the new imposed deadline. The signed form from a designated entity should remain sufficient. Adding a new deadline would be unreasonable, create confusion, and lead to unnecessary conflict at polling places when citizens—unaware of the change—are denied entry despite having valid documentation. This would place an unfair burden on Election Judges and disrupt orderly election administration.

For these reasons, the SBE should not pass this regulation change.

Respectfully submitted,

Kate Strauch Sullivan

Baltimore County Central Committee

“The truth is like a lion; you don’t have to defend it. Set it free; it will defend itself.”

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Message ID	<019701dc947f\$8bfccbf0\$a3f663d0\$@gmail.com>
From	"Dennis Evans" [REDACTED]
To	<info.sbe@maryland.gov>
Date	Mon, Feb 2, 2026 at 03:07 PM(Incoming)
Subject	Challenger and Watcher process
Thread Subject	Challenger and Watcher process
Return-Path	[REDACTED]

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For these reasons, the SBE should not add this deadline.

Respectively: Dennis W Evans